

Chapter 137-1

After leaving the public security bureau, the wind grew even stronger.

Liang Shi quickened her pace for several steps before getting into the car.

She inserted the car key and turned on the heater, finally blocking out the howling wind outside.

The wind whistled as it swept up the damp, withered branches and rotting leaves of the city. People on both sides of the road braced against the wind as they walked, their hair blown into disarray.

Liang Shi, who had just endured the baptism of the fierce wind outside, was no exception.

Using her ten fingers as a comb, Liang Shi casually smoothed out her somewhat messy hair.

Chen Liuying's words still echoed in her mind.

—It was like the thought was just in my head, so I did it.

—Who knows?

—No one instigated me, and I didn't think about the consequences.

—Do I regret it? I don't know either. It's already come to this anyway.

Chen Liuying's tone had been very confused, only becoming resolute again toward the end when she said: "Even if I regretted it, you wouldn't let me go anyway, so why should I regret anything?"

Chen Liuying said: "The only thing I regret is not gouging out your glands."

Liang Shi had then asked her: "Why are you so obsessed with gouging out my glands?"

Chen Liuying fell into confusion again because of her question, asking once more: "Yeah, why is that?"

But she didn't say anything more to Liang Shi.

After she herself emerged from her period of confusion, she gave a big yawn and said with a hooked smile: "Why should I tell you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"What do you want to find out from me?" Chen Liuying scoffed lightly. "I'll never let you know."

Liang Shi hadn't expected Chen Liuying to be so vigilant.

Or perhaps Chen Liuying simply felt pure revulsion toward her.

Yet Liang Shi said: "Why do you hate me so much? Is it simply because I stole your spotlight? But in the entertainment industry, there are so many people more capable than you, and so many people competing with you from the same period. Why... why is it specifically me?"

Liang Shi spoke with measured cadence, attempting to lead Chen Liuying into her verbal trap.

But Chen Liuying was completely impervious. "Think whatever you want."

That single sentence blocked off all of Liang Shi's overflowing thoughts.

But what Chen Liuying had said earlier was enough to set Liang Shi's mind racing.

The System had once said that important plot points would not be changed.

Yet now she had essentially changed part of the outcome—Chen Liuying, who was supposed to gouge out her glands, was now in prison, and her glands had not been gouged out. Additionally, she had done something that didn't happen in the original book—temporarily marked Xu Qingzhu.

Furthermore, Xu Qingzhu's glands were also still intact, and she had never had any thoughts of gouging out Xu Qingzhu's glands.

The outcomes of the two major plot points from the original book had actually been changed.

Such changes would inevitably trigger a butterfly effect.

Now everything was developing in a positive direction, so where would this butterfly effect manifest?

After meeting with Chen Liuying, Liang Shi's mood had become somewhat poor.

There was an indescribable feeling of oppression.

Since she had temporarily marked Xu Qingzhu and said she would take responsibility, what she needed to do next was certainly to face off against the righteous Alpha, Lu Jiayi.

That was the most important storyline.

Lu Jiayi, as the female lead, was far superior to her in both external conditions and inner qualities.

At any rate, she was far superior to the original owner.

Liang Shi had never met Lu Jiayi, so she couldn't make comparisons.

But since Xu Qingzhu, as one of the female leads in the book, was already so outstanding, the other one who could stand as her equal naturally wouldn't be lacking either.

Chapter 137-2

Liang Shi, who had never attended university, compared to someone who was fluent in seven languages and held a master's degree from a prestigious overseas university—it was like the difference between mud and clouds.¹

The reason she came to see Chen Liuying today was to figure out whether Chen Liuying had developed tremendous hatred toward her because of the series of things she had done and thus wanted to do this, or whether it was due to the force majeure of the original book that led her to kidnap Xu Qingzhu and stubbornly want to gouge out her glands?

From how things looked now, the latter seemed more likely.

And in order to fight against Chen Liuying, this force majeure, she had been slashed by a knife across her collarbone and arm. Although it wasn't as painful as having her glands gouged out, she had still paid a price.

Moreover, she had also been transported back to her original world for half a month.

All signs indicated that if she wanted to bring change to this world, she would inevitably have to pay a price.

Just like the balance mechanism the System had mentioned before.

Her appearance brought changes to the original world, so she had to bear the corresponding consequences.

These consequences would definitely be negative.

Liang Shi was very unhappy about this realization.

But there was nothing she could do.

Just as she was lost in thought, a strange mechanical sound suddenly rang out in her mind.

Thank goodness, at least there was no longer that electric current sound like a drill buzzing in her head.

The System returned once again: 【Ding dong! Congratulations, Host, on completing all main quests and side quests in the alternate world. The capture target's favorability toward you has already maxed out. You can now continue developing along the storyline!】

【Currently, all passages between dimensional worlds have been closed and are undergoing repairs. Rest assured, the current Little Tong is no longer the Little Tong that used to have bugs! After this upgrade and modification, Little Tong now possesses the universe's latest chip, containing knowledge from tens of millions of dimensional worlds, and can provide you with comprehensive services.】

【PS: Although your main quest has been completed, because you haven't finished the side quest you selected yourself, Little Tong will continue to accompany you in your growth until you choose to close the connection with Little Tong.】

After the System finished its long string of announcements, Liang Shi directly asked: "When you say continue developing along the storyline, are you telling me to leave Xu Qingzhu and make room for the Alpha from the original book?"

Liang Shi asked very seriously, with a hint of worry, terrified that the System would say yes.

But the System fell silent.

It remained silent for so long that Liang Shi thought it had disappeared.

Yet it abruptly appeared again.

System: 【The current storyline has already become chaotic. All the nodes have been crossed and intertwined, and events that didn't appear in the original book have occurred, so the situation is currently unknown.】

And in order to give Liang Shi a more intuitive understanding, the System generously transmitted the complete subsequent storyline of the original book to her.

Liang Shi: "....."

What the hell.

It was enough to make her want to curse.

When Liang Shi had first arrived here, she was completely in the dark, only half-understanding the situation of this world.

All she knew were the major settings and nodes on her own storyline, as well as Xu Qingzhu's subsequent major nodes and settings.

She had struggled for so long knowing nothing, and now the System was finally willing to give her the original book?

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It was so infuriating.

But no matter how angry she was, she still needed to first understand the original book's storyline.

Everything was pretty much the same as what Liang Shi had known before, just with some details filled in.

For example, Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi had met at a banquet. At that time, Xu Qingzhu had been schemed against by a petty person and pushed into the swimming pool. Lu Jiayi was the first to jump in and rescue her.

After that back and forth, the two became acquainted.

Lu Jiayi was from the capital. She had many siblings in her family, and many people coveted the family fortune. As the first-in-line heir of the Lu family, she was surrounded by wolves and tigers—a pure example of "beautiful, strong, and tragic."²

No one could refuse someone who was highly capable yet gentle and gentlemanly, who was "beautiful, strong, and tragic."

Especially when this "beautiful, strong, and tragic" character had so much in common with Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu could play the cello; Lu Jiayi could play the piano and violin.

Xu Qingzhu liked Chopin and Monet; Lu Jiayi liked them too.

Xu Qingzhu had read Tagore's poetry anthology over and over again, and reciting it purely in English was no problem. Lu Jiayi could not only discuss Tagore with her but also Shakespeare's plays, Homer's epics, and all sorts of very obscure things.

They didn't just talk about literature and dreams—they could also discuss astronomy and geography, celestial bodies and stars, and gravitational pull.

The book wrote that the most boring thing the two of them ever did together was sitting in the study doing gaokao³ practice questions together.

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1. "The difference between mud and clouds" (雲泥之別) is a Chinese idiom meaning an enormous gap or disparity between two things, like the distance between the sky and the ground. ↩
 2. "Beautiful, strong, and tragic" (美強慘) is a popular Chinese internet slang term describing a character archetype who is physically attractive, highly capable/powerful, but has a tragic backstory or circumstances. It's a beloved trope in romance novels. ↩
 3. Gaokao (高考) is China's national college entrance examination, a highly competitive and important standardized test that largely determines which university a student can attend. ↩

Chapter 137-3

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For Xu Qingzhu, who came from a science background and especially loved analyzing logic, Lu Jiayi could quickly get her points, watch mystery and detective novels and dramas with her, and even watch horror films together.

She could be called the perfect partner.

And Lu Jiayi had never let Xu Qingzhu down. She remembered all their anniversaries clearly, was very attentive to Xu Qingzhu's family members, could guide Xu Qingzhu when she was lost, and could also be her strong harbor from the storm.

Later, Lu Jiayi secretly collaborated with Xu Qingzhu's friends to throw her a party on a luxury cruise ship without her knowledge. When the party ended, it was exactly Xu Qingzhu's birthday.

She got down on one knee and proposed to Xu Qingzhu. That day, there were also reporters from many media outlets present.

The scene was widely reported by the media and became the talk of the town for a while.

Xu Qingzhu became the love rival of many Omegas.

For no other reason than Lu Jiayi, as the first-in-line heir of the Lu family, had impeccable looks, talent, and character—not a single flaw to be found.

After their marriage, the two even had a pair of twin daughters through high-tech means. The gouging out of Xu Qingzhu's glands didn't have much impact.

They lived happily ever after.

And thus, the grand finale.

Liang Shi: "....."

She remained quiet for a long time after reading it.

The System gave a somewhat frightened light cough: 【Host, are you okay?】

Liang Shi smiled a death smile: "What do you think?"

System: 【.....You're not the kind of person who would be defeated by this small difficulty.】

Liang Shi: "Hehe."

She reasonably suspected that the reason the System hadn't let her know the complete plot back then was because it was afraid she would desert at the last moment after seeing it.

Who wouldn't be confused after seeing this?

It was purely a story of a "parachute" defeating the "childhood sweetheart."¹

Although she had been kidnapped together with the childhood sweetheart, that kidnapping had also brought Xu Qingzhu wounds that couldn't heal, and even caused her greater harm afterward.

The childhood sweetheart was just a stepping stone for the parachute.

The parachute even helped Xu Qingzhu cure her PTSD.

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Was there even any competition?

Might as well just surrender directly.

Liang Shi had a headache at this moment, but the System heard her inner monologue and explained: 【That's not the case. The reason the complete storyline wasn't transmitted to you back then was because, as an incomplete person, you didn't have the right to know the storylines of other characters in this book. That would have violated others' destiny privacy.】

The implication being—back then you couldn't even survive, so what did you deserve to know.

System: 【Now, because of your return, a butterfly effect has been triggered in the characters and plot, so the complete storyline can be told to you. This also counts as compensation for you.】

Liang Shi felt something was off the moment she heard that statement, and suddenly asked: "So since I've seen Lu Jiayi's destiny privacy, for the sake of the balance mechanism, will you also compensate Lu Jiayi with something?"

The System fell silent again.

After the silence, the System said: 【Yes, correspondingly, twenty favorability points have been added for her with Xu Qingzhu.】

Liang Shi: "....."

"Can I take it back?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【Once distributed, it cannot be changed.】

Liang Shi: "....."

This System was insane.

Who could defeat a perfect parachute?

Liang Shi's head was throbbing.

If Lu Jiayi had flaws, it would be one thing, but she was a perfect paper character created by the author. The original author, in order to create a dream for Omegas, had devoted a large amount of narrative focus to this Alpha, Lu Jiayi.

After reading it, even Liang Shi felt... she could marry her.

She herself would be fine with it.

Liang Shi personally didn't have a strong sense of Alpha-Omega boundaries anyway. To her, they were all women.

Even she, the love rival, thought Lu Jiayi was flawless—she really was perfect to a certain degree.

Afterward, the System reminded her of her final side quest: collect all evidence favorable to the original owner and submit it to the Interstellar Court.

Liang Shi couldn't even be bothered to give it a glance.

She had never seen such a terrible System!!

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1. "Parachute" (天降, tiān jiàng, literally "descended from the sky") and "childhood sweetheart" (青梅, qīng méi, literally "green plum") are common romance novel tropes. A "parachute" refers to a love interest who appears suddenly later in the story, while a "childhood sweetheart" refers to someone who has known the protagonist since childhood. There's often rivalry between these two character types in romance stories, with debates about which deserves to end up with the protagonist. ↩

Chapter 137-4

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After being stirred up by Chen Liuying and the System, Liang Shi had completely lost all desire.

She even felt somewhat avoidant about going to find Xu Qingzhu.

So in the afternoon, she took the opportunity to visit Gu Xingyue at the hospital.

Currently, the case involving Gu Xingyue and Yang Jiani was still going through the process. Yang Jiani was temporarily detained at the detention center, while Gu Xingyue was still in the hospital.

Liang Shi had previously attended Director Gu Yingbo's funeral and had chatted with Gu Zhaoyuan several times.

Gu Zhaoyuan said the re-establishment of the orphanage should be completed within this year.

He didn't want to drag it out too long.

Gu Yingbo's passing had sounded an alarm for Gu Zhaoyuan—people really don't know when they'll leave, so do things as early as possible and don't procrastinate.

At Gu Yingbo's funeral, Gu Xingyue had not attended.

Liang Shi also learned some things from Zhao Xuning. Ever since Yang Jiani was arrested, Gu Xingyue had been staying in the hospital without any movement.

She was as quiet as a wooden sculpture.

Because her situation was special, she was still in a single-patient room with police guards outside.

The case hadn't been finalized yet, so she also had to remain under supervision.

But she showed no reaction at all.

She hadn't seen Liang Shi before, nor had she seen Gu Zhaoyuan. She just stayed alone in the hospital room—getting IV drips when it was time for IV drips, taking medicine when it was time for medicine, eating when it was time to eat.

The nurses all said they had never seen such a quiet patient.

After discussing with Liang Shi, Zhao Xuning had locked the paternity test results for Feng Xian and Gu Xingyue in a safe.

Afterward, Feng Xian had come to the hospital for a follow-up checkup once.

That time, Zhao Xuning had deliberately arranged for her to have an "accidental encounter" with Gu Xingyue, who was being wheeled out by a nurse to get some sun.

Feng Xian stared at Gu Xingyue's back for a long time.

Zhao Xuning thought she had sensed something, but Feng Xian said: "That girl looks so hopeless."

Zhao Xuning was a person of few words, didn't know how to comfort people, and didn't know what to say, so she said nothing.

After understanding the basic situation, Liang Shi applied again to see Gu Xingyue, but was rejected again.

Gu Xingyue didn't want to see anyone.

Liang Shi had no choice but to go bother Zhao Xuning in her office.

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"Are you really going to get an annual pass for the hospital?" Zhao Xuning was exasperated.

Liang Shi: "After not seeing each other for so long, don't you even want to see me?"

Zhao Xuning said coldly: "No."

Liang Shi: "....."

It happened to be close to when Zhao Xuning got off work, so Liang Shi said they could have dinner together.

But Zhao Xuning reminded her: "Aren't you going to pick up your wife from work? She just finished her heat period, you know."

Liang Shi: "....."

When Liang Shi was about to leave, she looked at her and said through gritted teeth: "Just you wait!"

Zhao Xuning laughed: "Wait for what? You're going to get back at me?"

Liang Shi: ".....Bad people will get their comeuppance from heaven."

Zhao Xuning scoffed lightly: "Get lost."

Liang Shi was provoked by her and immediately said: "If heaven doesn't deal with you, Shen Hui will."

At the mention of Shen Hui, Zhao Xuning's expression changed, and that faint trace of a smile immediately disappeared.

Then Liang Shi added: "Oh, I forgot. Shen Hui doesn't deal with you anymore either."

The folder in Zhao Xuning's hand flew directly toward her, but Liang Shi had already left through the door.

It only hit the door.

Liang Shi then drove to Minghui Jewelry. It happened to be rush hour, and there was a surging crowd outside.

Bored, Liang Shi turned on the car stereo and gazed at the crowd outside.

She sent Xu Qingzhu a message: 【Not off work yet?】

Xu Qingzhu didn't reply.

After a long while, when the sun was almost setting, Liang Shi was already getting drowsy.

Only then did Xu Qingzhu come out of the office building, and beside her was Sun Chengcheng.

Sun Chengcheng still had that sweet girl, energetic image. Back then, Liang Shi had let her guard down precisely because of her image.

But at this moment, she stood beside Xu Qingzhu and looked quite familiar with her.

Xu Qingzhu took the book she handed over. Although she was somewhat cold and distant, she wasn't exactly pushing her thousands of miles away.

As Xu Qingzhu walked toward her car, Sun Chengcheng suddenly called out to her and even adjusted her collar for her.

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Liang Shi immediately became alert. Just as she pushed open the car door to get out, Xu Qingzhu sent her a reply: 【Stay calm and don't be impatient.】

— 【Don't meet with her.】